

TULSI
TANTI

50, WIND TURBINE MANUFACTURER
CMD, SUZLON ENERGY
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1995 Rs 6 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,030 crore

WINDTALKER

Fourteen years ago, when the textile business of a Surat-based businessman, Tulsi Tanti, was facing a crisis, thanks to escalating power costs, he decided to get to the root of the problem. Born into a farmer's family, Tanti had heard about an alternative source of energy, windmills, and decided to give it a shot. He used his personal savings and borrowed from friends and family, and finally managed to raise Rs 6 crore. As he commissioned two windmills along the country's west coast to supply electricity to his plant in Gujarat, he knew that he had stumbled upon something big.

It eventually led to the creation of the Pune-based Suzlon Energy—derived from the adage *sujh bujh ke loan lena* (be careful about a loan)—which sold its first wind turbine in 1995. By 2001, the textile business had been hived off and Tanti, along with his three siblings, plunged into wind-turbine generation. Today, with factories across four continents, Suzlon is the fifth-largest wind-turbine maker in the world. Its client repertoire extends to 20 countries and boasts of biggies like Bajaj Auto, Tata Group and Reliance, many of whom are enjoying power at 50 paise per unit.

Earlier customers would buy turbines and have them installed on their premises, but the results were erratic. Suzlon introduced the concept of wind farms where it identified areas where there were good winds, installed a host of turbines for various customers and transported energy through the grid. That is what changed the game.

But like any other venture, Suzlon's journey has also not been without its share of setbacks. The company's IPO in 2005 left both the promoters and investors very rich. But the recent market crash and reports of poor product quality have seen the company's share fall 70 per cent in October this year and its market capitalisation go down by 90 per cent in November. Moreover, a few months ago, Edison International, a California-based utility, turned down delivery of 150 turbines after complaining of faulty equipment. Analysts are hopeful that the company will soon bounce back. Tulsibhai, as he is fondly known among his colleagues, is an inspiring leader. "That gives us the confidence that this too will pass," says a manager. The winds of change may soon blow in Suzlon's favour.

by Nandini Vaish

role MODELS

Rates three companies, Infosys, Reliance, and Tata, highly

turning POINT

In 1994, his textile business suffered due to high power costs

what's in A NAME

Suzlon means *sujh bujh ke loan lena* (be careful about a loan)

SHANKAR PAUL